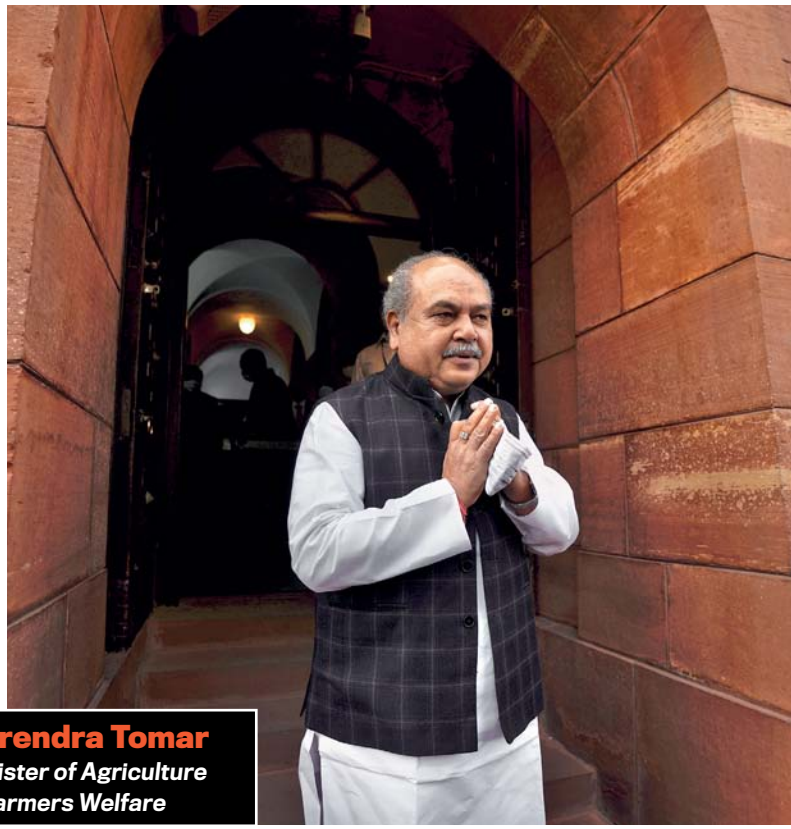
HYBRID TO HITECH

The ministries of Agriculture and Public Distribution have both pushed hard to increase the use of tech in their sectors

By Anilesh S. Mahajan



Narendra Tomar
Minister of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare

AP

IF **THERE IS ONE ISSUE** that will likely haunt Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP in the next general election, it will be the party's attempt to ram through agricultural reforms in September 2020, which triggered fierce and sustained protests by farmers' unions. The protests eventually led to a rollback of the laws in November that year—the first time in PM Modi's eight years in power that a law passed by Parliament had to be repealed. The BJP's failure derailed its attempt to liberalise market access to farm produce. As a result, the ministry of agriculture and farmers welfare under Narendra Tomar has had to continue with the public capital-supported mechanism currently in place.

The ministry's roadmap for the future includes a push for chemical-free organic farming and the development of a network of farmer-producer organisations (FPOs) to create new market intermediaries. Despite the Centre's inability to open up agricultural markets to the private sector, several major agricultural states—including Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat—have reformed their APMCs (agricultural produce market committees) to allow the sale of agricultural produce outside APMC markets. Tomar will

WHAT'S DONE

- Setting up the India Digital Ecosystem for Agriculture to provide tech-based support to farmers and understand their policy requirements
- Policies to deploy modern technology (drones, GIS, remote sensing and so on)
- Income support under the PM Kisan Yojana, as well as soil health cards, crop insurance and so on
- The Pesticide Management Bill has been cleared by a standing committee of Parliament

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Set up a committee to formalise the MSP-based trading of agricultural produce
- Get the Pesticide Management Bill passed by Parliament
- Develop a clear roadmap/ mission plan for organic agriculture
- Increase the pace of crop diversification